



FAMILY COURT DATA REPORT · STATE SERIES · NO. 49

WISCONSIN

WHAT FAMILIES ARE REPORTING.

Pulled from the Family Rights Registry — a cross-location dataset on what pro se parents are actually experiencing inside Wisconsin's family courts and child-welfare system.

73

WISCONSIN FAMILIES ON RECORD ·
143 CHILDREN IMPACTED · 18
MONTHS MEDIAN MONTHS LOST OF
PARENTING TIME

DATA AS OF
SEPTEMBER 8, 2026

COUNTIES REPRESENTED
36 OF 72

COMPILED BY
MEG · STANDWITHMEG.COM

THE HEADLINE NUMBERS

WISCONSIN AT A GLANCE.

Across 73 Wisconsin families reporting through the Family Rights Registry, the patterns are consistent: long durations in court, serious financial loss, and a disproportionate number of parents going unrepresented because they ran out of money fighting.

CHILDREN IMPACTED 143 73 of 73 families reported child counts	MEDIAN FAMILY BURDEN \$68,000 median across 45 families reporting 3+ categories	MEDIAN MONTHS LOST 18 of parenting time	WENT PRO SE 64.4% 47 of 73 who answered; 31 of 73 ran out of money
SUBMISSIONS 73	AVG CHILDREN / FAMILY 2.0	FAMILIES REPORTING CHILDREN 73 of 73	COUNTIES REPRESENTED 36

WHY THIS REPORT EXISTS.

On January 29, 2024, I lost custody of all five of my children.

- NO TRIAL.
- NO QUESTIONING.
- NO SUBSTANTIATED ABUSE.

It took only a signature on an ex parte emergency order to erase a mother. I refused to disappear. I fought back, and built the Family Rights Registry so Wisconsin families — and families across every represented location — would stop being invisible to the data. This report is their record.

— MEG · [STANDWITHMEG.COM](https://standwithmeg.com)

02 THE COST OF WISCONSIN FAMILY COURT

Legal fees are the largest reported expense, but they are not the only one. Lost wages, evaluation costs, and reunification services compound the financial loss — pushing most families toward pro se representation once their savings run out.

EXPENSE CATEGORY	RESPONSES	MEDIAN	MEAN	TOTAL REPORTED
Attorney Fees	53	\$20,000	\$56,912	\$3,016,350
Lost Wages	40	\$10,000	\$31,678	\$1,267,140
Other Court Fees	30	\$1,750	\$9,085	\$272,550
Therapy / Evaluations	36	\$3,000	\$9,390	\$338,025
Reunification Services	21	\$120	\$1,865	\$39,170
GAL Fees	51	\$4,800	\$8,026	\$409,350
Asset Loss	32	\$55,000	\$134,651	\$4,308,824
Median Family Burden (45 families reporting 3+ categories)	—	\$68,000	—	—

Median vs. mean: Median is the middle reported amount, so it better reflects the typical reporting family when a few very large expenses appear. Mean is the average across reporting families and can be pulled higher by outliers. **Median Family Burden** is the median of total reported expenses across families who reported costs in 3 or more expense categories with a combined total of at least \$1,000 — a true median of real family totals, restricted to families who filled out enough of the financial section to characterize their case and excluding obvious data-entry artifacts.

LOST PARENTING TIME · MONTHS

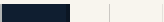
Median months lost		18	1.5 yrs
Mean months lost		31	2.6 yrs
Total across all families		1,681	140.1 yrs

03 WHO IS REPORTING · WISCONSIN

Most families documenting in Wisconsin are currently active in, or recently closed out of, long-running cases. Nearly half have lost all contact with their children. Percentages below use only families who answered that specific topic.

CASE STATUS · SYSTEM AFFECTED

CASE STATUS

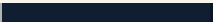
Active case: stuck or delayed		34	47%
Case closed: more than 2 years ago		11	15%
Case closed: within last 2 years		10	14%
Not provided		10	14%
Active case: progress being made		7	10%

SYSTEM AFFECTED

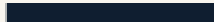
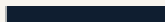
Family Court Only		36	49%
Both Family Court and CPS		28	38%
CPS Only		6	8%
Unknown		3	4%

DURATION · CUSTODY OUTCOMES

TIME IN SYSTEM

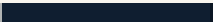
1 – 3 years		25	34%
5 – 10 years		19	26%
3 – 5 years		11	15%
Over 10 years		7	10%
6 months – 1 year		7	10%

CUSTODY STATUS

50/50 Joint		21	29%
No Contact / Total Loss of Access		19	26%
Visitation Only		19	26%
Children in Foster Care		6	8%
Full Custody		5	7%

GEOGRAPHY · ALLEGATIONS REPORTED

TOP COUNTIES

Dane		7	11%
Waukesha		7	11%
Milwaukee		5	8%
Barron		2	3%
Polk		2	3%
Outagamie		2	3%

TOP ALLEGATIONS REPORTED

Family Court False Accusations (Domestic Violence/Abuse/Alienation)		21	29%
High Conflict Divorce		17	23%
False Accusations CPS (Non-Medical) (Vengeful ex-partner, malicious report)		12	16%
Other		7	10%
Medical CPS (Medical Child Abuse allegations, disagreement with doctors)		4	5%

04 PARENT VOICES — WISCONSIN

Selected voice excerpts appear here for readability. Every approved, shareable Wisconsin comment is printed in full in the appendix that follows.



It has destroyed my family I don't even have a family anymore. My kids are no longer my kids.

— ROBYN

ON THE REPORTED ALLEGATIONS

The system to protect my family, ripped us apart, chewed us up, charged me to earn my rights back to even talk to my son-at the cost of our family home. We were never provided a fair trial or any legal steps to make this make sense. No due process, did not allow the "experts" [...]

— WISCONSIN PARENT · DANIELLE

MORE VOICES FROM WISCONSIN

This system with CPS has destroyed my heart. The relationship with my children is severed and it feels so heavy on my heart I think about them everyday and all I want to do is hug them.

— JAMIE

Destroyed my family and traumatized 2 toddler girls in a way I experienced as a kid and NEVER wanted them to suffer.

— ALYSSA

Lengthened the process, falsely accused me the mom and victim of domestic violence of parents alienation, kids are terrified, kids have NO voice, daughter Noe has mental health issues and diagnosis of OCD and is begging for her voice to be heard in court. I am losing my home [...]

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

Failed my children and I. We cannot count on any protection in the hands of the system. The system is the Devil. Lost trust within the system. They have traumatized us beyond the trauma we already had with the family abuse.

— CRYSTAL

04 PARENT VOICES, CONTINUED



I was made to pay to give my children away to my abuser including my daughter who is not biologically his. I was threatened with 6 months of jail time if I didn't pay GAL fees all while still having no access to my children and trying to rebuild my life.

— CHANDI

The system came into our lives and destroyed everything with a wrecking ball. My child has suffered extensive abuse and trauma, and now suffers from PTSD.

— MICHELLE

System failed to protect my child from abuse. Trauma.

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

They denied me due process, stripped me of my business, investment properties, and all income, denied maintenance, and ignored documented attorney abuse, resulting in over \$700,000 in losses, forced reliance on public assistance, homelessness, and the destruction of my family.

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

Destroyed my family, injured my kids and caused them more harm - it will take them decades to understand what happened and to heal.

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

After years of (well documented) domestic abuse and coercive control, my abuser has been rewarded for the harm he caused. I have no home, no transportation, no stability whatsoever, a lien on any future income, tens of thousands of dollars in debt, and severe chronic PTSD. I've [...]

— KIRA

It has given both my daughter and I trauma. We no longer trust anyone to actually help us who is supposed to help.

— DAWN

The system has destroyed my family.

— ROBERT

My daughter was ripped away from me and I have been forced to relive the traumas of the past over and over. They have cause great harm in my daughters development.

— CORTNEE

04 PARENT VOICES, CONTINUED



This corrupt court has destroyed my life my daughters relationship with me by allowing them to be manipulated by the narcissist parent guilty of parental alienation. Her narcissistic parents financially destroyed my 18 year career because I used to work for them and then they [...]

— TYLER

I lost my children and essential my right, and the ability to ever get them back.

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

Allowed me to be disrespected and slandered with no objection

— DENISE

Family court has torn my 3 babies away from their only safety and placed them into the hands of their physical and sexual abuser.

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

They've used the very system that has put there to protect from this kind of behavior to further systematically abuse my child and tear away the father trying to protect him. It's resulted in nearly 10 years of alienation and I'm afraid of the online interactions he's having.

— RYAN

I lost my kiddo for protecting her against the abuse and neglect from her father and family

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

They have tore my family apart and caused many hours of pain and suffering for not only myself but my child, my other 3 kids, and her father.

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

I do not see my kids though they are adults now. My daughter is a narcissist, devil worshiper. My son has finally realized how messed up the court system is. I pray for them both.

— APRIL

This system forced the liquidation of assets and belongings, purchased with disability income, imposed restraining orders without evidence, involved law enforcement, enabled ongoing harassment, silenced my autistic son, confiscated his phone after he attempted to escape by [...]

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

04 PARENT VOICES, CONTINUED



My ex was convicted of second degree sexual assault of a child. My daughter was the victim. He threatened to kills us. I was granted a 10 year DVPO and he was sentenced to 4 years in prison, 6 years extended supervision, and is a lifelong registered sex offender. My two young [...]

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

I have watched my children deteriorate physically and psychologically. I have experienced the death of hope, the loss of the mother i wanted to be, the life I worked for stolen, the relationship I had with my children sabotaged.

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

The system has trafficked my 3 beautiful daughters out of my safe home and into their perpetrators home full-time. They have lied over and over and ripped me apart in every way imaginable to fit their false narratives.

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

It has taken me from being a daily mother to allowing the father to push me out of my kid's lives entirely.

— SAMANTHA

Put my child and myself in danger, no help or protection, gave my child to the abuser. Left me broken, shattered, and facing criminal charges based on made up stories.

— HOLLY

In my experience the system frowns upon any type of abuse besides directly physical being brought up, does not give victims the right to speak, and it brings children into dangerous situations. It allows for predators to take advantage of "court-rulings" and to gain power over [...]

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

I'm a single mom and my family is seemingly falling apart in the worst ways now. It should have come back together years ago.

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

The court's have completely devoured and ruined our family with no hope of reunification until maybe after adulthood; the alienation and the reprogramming is so bad they were once best friends with Dad and now they wanted anything to do with us for three years.

— CRYSTAL

Family Court has caused so much unnecessary stress, depression, anxiety, and trauma when I was already going through the most difficult time in my life and I still am. It's not over yet. I still don't know what is going to happen. We don't need uncertainty during these times. [...]

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

04 PARENT VOICES, CONTINUED



The continued lack of concern for the children is ignored, they have no voice in the state of Wisconsin. 5 years later I am stilling fight to keep my children!

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

This system has completely failed my family. It broke apart not only a mother from her firstborn son but my son from his brothers and loving stepfather and loving grandmother. The system has put in place false narratives which now is defamating to me because of how easy it is to [...]

— JAMIE

The unwillingness of the system actors to investigate, draw sound conclusions, and act in the best interests of the children is disgusting. The collusion to increase billing hours is horrible.

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

These monsters stole my babies and sold their childhood for their own profits. I'll never get those moments back... they stole my life when they stole my kids.

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

I've lost huge amounts of time of a loving daughter, from interference as well as alienation. College educations for my kids were paid to lawyers for years of conflict generated for the sake of additional litigation

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

Unfairly judged. I told the judge about how my children are not dressed or fed well and that court should care about their well being but he chuckled at me and ignored me. I told the court that I lived in a different state at the time of divorce and he still ignored his out of [...]

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

every negative thing you could think about. and all for revenge.

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

51 Wisconsin parents submitted approved, shareable comments. 40 selected excerpts appear here; the full comments begin on the next page.

05 FULL PARENT COMMENTS — WISCONSIN

The comments below are the full approved, publicly shareable survey comments from Wisconsin families. Data-only and do-not-share submissions are excluded from this public appendix.

The system to protect my family, ripped us apart, chewed us up, charged me to earn my rights back to even talk to my son- at the cost of our family home. We were never provided a fair trial or any legal steps to make this make sense. No due process, did not allow the "experts" to be deposed. As a result, the 457 days my son was ripped away from his "safe" parent and family- his brother and grandmother as well- CPS then placed him right back at home with me. However, now that my son is home I have FULL PLACEMENT and NO CUSTODY. Can't make this up. I am a teacher. I work with kids my son's age everyday. What the courts are doing NEEDS URGENT REFORM. Thank you SO much Megan for your voice. I get through many of my days because of you. I am more than willing to be involved to get the word out there and expose each and every one.

— DANIELLE

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— ROBYN

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— ALYSSA

Lengthened the process, falsely accused me the mom and victim of domestic violence of parents alienation, kids are terrified, kids have NO voice, daughter Noe has mental health issues and diagnosis of OCD and is begging for her voice to be heard in court. I am losing my home because I can't afford to keep fighting my x. He makes half a million a year and has 4 attorneys, he files false allegations and I get drained financially fighting him. Our kids are slowly dying inside every time they have to be with him and be abused by him. No one will listen to the kids. Their doctors have called the police and cps and crickets.

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

05 FULL PARENT COMMENTS, CONTINUED

Failed my children and I. We cannot count on any protection in the hands of the system. The system is the Devil. Lost trust within the system. They have traumatized us beyond the trauma we already had with the family abuse.

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05 FULL PARENT COMMENTS, CONTINUED

After years of (well documented) domestic abuse and coercive control, my abuser has been rewarded for the harm he caused. I have no home, no transportation, no stability whatsoever, a lien on any future income, tens of thousands of dollars in debt, and severe chronic PTSD. I've been pillaged to the point where I have literally nothing left to give; so now they're trying to throw me in jail to shut me up. My money, children, and reputation weren't enough, now they're trying to steal my life force and will to live. Family court is a system of legalized torture and slavery for profit.

— KIRA

It has given both my daughter and I trauma. We no longer trust anyone to actually help us who is supposed to help.

— DAWN

The system has destroyed my family.

— ROBERT

My daughter was ripped away from me and I have been forced to relive the traumas of the past over and over. They have cause great harm in my daughters development.

— CORTNEE

This corrupt court has destroyed my life my daughters relationship with me by allowing them to be manipulated by the narcissist parent guilty of parental alienation. Her narcissistic parents financially destroyed my 18 year career because I used to work for them and then they threw me away like I was garbage after I helped build a profitable business. The court is do corrupt and needs to be held accountable for their treason in kidnapping our children for money.

— TYLER

I lost my children and essential my right, and the ability to ever get them back.

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05 FULL PARENT COMMENTS, CONTINUED

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— APRIL

This system forced the liquidation of assets and belongings, purchased with disability income, imposed restraining orders without evidence, involved law enforcement, enabled ongoing harassment, silenced my autistic son, confiscated his phone after he attempted to escape by dialing 911, caused severe trauma and mental health damages requiring significant therapy and ultimately jailed me for falling apart, tearing my family apart and stripping me and my son of our rights.

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

05 FULL PARENT COMMENTS, CONTINUED

My ex was convicted of second degree sexual assault of a child. My daughter was the victim. He threatened to kills us. I was granted a 10 year DVPO and he was sentenced to 4 years in prison, 6 years extended supervision, and is a lifelong registered sex offender. My two young sons who were 18 months at 4 years at the time of his arrest were ordered by the family court to be driven to the prison by complete strangers (men from a jail prayer ministry) to visit him. Immediately upon his release from prison he was awarded weekly 4 hour visits with the same church men supervising. Despite my boys now being 8 and 11 and having fulfilled lives and relationships. He continues to file motion after motín after motion which is a form of post separation abuse as a means to financially harm me. The criminal court advocated for me and my kids and I felt hope that we would be protected. Unfortunately in family court all they care about is his right to “meaningful and reoccurring placement” instead of the boys’ rights to be safe.

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

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— HOLLY

05 FULL PARENT COMMENTS, CONTINUED

In my experience the system frowns upon any type of abuse besides directly physical being brought up, does not give victims the right to speak, and it brings children into dangerous situations. It allows for predators to take advantage of “court-rulings” and to gain power over their victims further. Context should be read in before every case, but this is seldom taken into account. For situations that include financial abuse, religious abuse, emotional torment, sexual abuse but not rape, and misogynistic relationships that involve a rather “controlling” and “intimidating” in nature, it seems as though nobody gives a rats ass. The system is built off of “documentation” but why should we wait for terrible things to happen for them to be proven to the court? At the expense of our childrens safety?! Why shouldn’t mothers who were victims of ANY type of abuse be heard- even if those types of abuse are COMMON to a “human being” but not COMMON in family court? If false allegations just keep getting dismissed, does that mean that either party can just start throwing them around willy nilly? No. This is not justice.

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

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Family Court has caused so much unnecessary stress, depression, anxiety, and trauma when I was already going through the most difficult time in my life and I still am. It's not over yet. I still don't know what is going to happen. We don't need uncertainty during these times. They work for us!

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05 FULL PARENT COMMENTS, CONTINUED

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— JAMIE

The unwillingness of the system actors to investigate, draw sound conclusions, and act in the best interests of the children is disgusting. The collusion to increase billing hours is horrible.

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— ANONYMOUS PARENT

Unfairly judged. I told the judge about how my children are not dressed or fed well and that court should care about their well being but he chuckled at me and ignored me. I told the court that I lived in a different state at the time of divorce and he stilled ignored his out of jurisdiction orders and my duo process completely issuing me to pay \$3000 a month specially when i got married again and now have two babies that need more support than my teen daughters with my ex.

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

every negative thing you could think about. and all for revenge.

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

05 FULL PARENT COMMENTS, CONTINUED

* Loss of physical custody * Chronic stress from ongoing court supervision * substantial Financial strain from required services, travel, and legal costs * Severe Emotional distress tied to uncertainty and separation * Completely Reduced autonomy in parenting decisions due to court mandates * Risk of long-term loss of parental rights by a court without jurisdiction

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

It's rarely truly in the best interest of the child. Just the court actors pockets.

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

Loss of time and memories!

— AMANDA

The system has broken my child because they believe 50/50 is what is just for the parents but refuse to acknowledge the ramifications of what that does to the child. The system is failing children and forcing them to be in situations their parent left. I have cared for my daughter 24/7 for 2,200+ days without the help from my ex husband and now she is being forced to go with her father and its causing her regression, baby talk, thumb sucking, separation anxiety, depression, school issues, refusing to sleep, night terrors, etc.

— AMANDA

They didn't charge me or wouldn't help me they waited to longer for me to do classes they lied to me about a lawyer when I got a lawyer my dad got me he didn't help me at all

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

I went to the system because my child was being kept from me they instead made it about money costing me all of the money I spent preparing for this new child, all of the money I spent to see this new child, broke approximately 12 codes and statutes among with unalienable rights. They tried to rub my name in the mud they tried to belittle me and treat me like a criminal and I literally presented this case just to see my child in the first place. My daughter has lost time with her brother I have lost time with my son my mother has lost time with her grandchild and my son has lost the ability to meet half of my family due to time restraints.

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

05 FULL PARENT COMMENTS, CONTINUED

Everyone I've met and dealt with through this case that works with CPS has told me over and over how good of a father I am but yet I sit here without tucking my daughter into bed every night. My daughter had a diaper rash for 4 months straight after they removed her from me for breaking a policy they had for me.

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

This system totally screwed up the family all I was doing was what was in her best interest I always looked at what was in her best interest and it looks like the gal the case worker the social worker that was for my daughter did what was in Ryan's best interest who is the father they cost me so much money and so much depression I almost shot myself in the head I had my daughter and raised her by myself for six and a half years without any of their help. Friendships were strained family ties broken my daughter doesn't even remember half the people on my side she lost connections to her brother and other people that we knew she was torn away from organizations that she was part of and nobody even cared so this just didn't hurt me it hurt my daughter too. Especially after they first had her during the first 6 weeks they had her they wouldn't let her talk to me they wouldn't let her see me and she fell and they didn't tell me about it it was her teacher that told me about it during her conferences and what changed is when they finally allowed me to see her and then they caused even more drama by having me supervised a paid supervisor to watch us sit and play for 4 hours that's \$200 an hour at twice a month that's \$1,600 a month and that went on for a year and a half that entire family is nothing but a narcissistic sociopathic psychotic piece of garbage.

— VICKI

Remove the child from their primary parents based off of allegations and no justified due process time as an emergency expert order is supposed to be temporary and it has been in place now almost 4 months pushing it towards almost being the new standard placement

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

Based on unverified allegations, I was separated from my children, leading to devastating consequences including my son's mental decline and PTSD diagnosis, another child developing severe anxiety, and the loss of our relationship, while I have been left financially unstable, lost my employment, and cannot afford medical care for my heart condition as well as dealing with on going police harassment now under DOJ review (ex husband is a local detective.)

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

05 FULL PARENT COMMENTS, CONTINUED

The system has put my son in the custody of a documented physically and emotional abusive parent with no supervision or monitoring. The system tore my sons mother from his life, the only constant and safe parenting he had known since birth 2013. The system im referring to here is CPS and the family court.

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

51 full approved Wisconsin comments are included in this appendix.

06 HOW TO READ THIS REPORT**WHAT THIS IS**

The Family Rights Registry is a public, parent-reported data collection run by Stand With Meg. Every figure in this Wisconsin report comes from Wisconsin respondents who voluntarily submitted survey entries about their experience inside family court and/or CPS.

This report is built to help families, advocates, reporters, and legislators see the patterns emerging in Wisconsin — not to replace formal research, and not to name individual judges or counties as responsible parties.

WHAT IT ISN'T

This is not a representative sample. Respondents self-select. The 73 Wisconsin families reporting here are not the universe of Wisconsin families in court — they are the families who found the survey, trusted it enough to submit, and told us what happened to them.

Financial figures are self-reported. Response counts and percentages use the number of families who answered that specific topic or financial field. The Median Family Burden headline is the median of total reported expenses across families who reported in three or more expense categories. Quotes are minimally edited.

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Data in this report was collected April 2024 – September 2026 through standwithmeg.com/family-rights-survey. Submissions are timestamped. Duplicate-submission heuristics use normalized email + location, with direct survey rows preferred over legacy rows and the newest row retained within each source. Categorical responses from multi-select and short-answer fields are normalized monthly.

Dollar fields exclude blank, negative, and obvious data-entry artifact values above the report's field caps. When asset-loss values contain a strong statistical outlier, the asset-loss mean and total are suppressed and only the median is reported. Lost-wage, attorney-fee, and asset-loss entries are self-reported and not corroborated against tax records or court filings.

Geographic reporting uses the county or regional field as submitted, with light normalization (e.g. "Butte silverbow" → "Butte–Silver Bow"). Quotes carry one of three public permission states: *Anonymous*, *First-name only*, or *Full attribution with consent to public use*. Court actor names appear only after 3 independent families name the same actor.

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ABOUT THIS REPORT

This report is based on self-reported survey submissions collected by Stand With Meg. Counts and categories reflect responses available at the time this packet was generated.

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